

Symbiosis students come from all over the world

NO. 1 SYMBIOSIS INTERNATIONAL (DEEMED UNIVERSITY), *Pune*

MANDAR DEODHAR

OUT OF THE BOX PEDAGOGY

THE MULTIFACETED APPROACH TO EXPANDING ITS STUDENTS' HORIZONS HAS MADE SYMBIOSIS ONE OF INDIA'S FOREMOST INSTITUTIONS IN PRIVATE EDUCATION

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni

In **1970, S.B. Mujumdar, then a professor of botany** at Fergusson College, Pune, began interacting with foreign students studying in the city and writing about the difficulties they faced. He soon launched the Symbiosis International Cultural Centre to better assimilate international students. Realising that these efforts were limited in scope, Mujumdar decided to enter the education sector, beginning with the Symbiosis English Language Teaching Institute (ELTIS) for students from non-English-speaking countries. This was followed by a law college in 1977, a business management institute in 1978 and, eventually, colleges for several more disciplines.

Symbiosis acquired deemed university status in 2002. Today, Symbiosis International (Deemed University) is a multidisciplinary institution with 45 institutes, 105 courses and programmes, more than 1,300 faculty members, and around 70,000 students from across India and 85 other countries. It operates six campuses in India and one in Dubai. The university's 400-acre Lavale campus, in the hills on Pune's outskirts, is divided into the Hill Base and Hill Top campuses and is home to over 19,000 students.

"The main differentiator between Symbiosis and other private universities is that it was established by a teacher," says Dr Vidya Yeravdekar, Mujumdar's daughter and current pro-chancellor, Symbiosis International (Deemed University). In 2019, Symbiosis became the first private institution in the country to establish a medical college exclusively for women. The Symbiosis Medical College for Women has one of the lowest